Description of the project's requirements

International Open Bidding Project / Séminaire Appel d'Offres International

A cross-generational platform for sharing skills and experience

1. Introduction

This year you will be working on an international team project. This means that every team has to complete a project, and that every team is international. This is not an "international competition" (France vs. Albania …), this is a competition between international teams.

Every team is composed of a balanced number of students with different skills (programming, graphic design, communication) so that the workload may be fairly shared. And every team is composed of students from 3 different countries.

It is up to you, students, to find the best way to work together and to communicate!

2. Work process

On the first day of the project, March 23rd, 9 AM UTC (10 am in Paris and Tirana, 4 pm in Hanoi), the object of the work you have to carry out is disclosed to you. This is the purpose of the present document (Section 4).

At the same time, the composition of the teams will be given.

The object is given to you as if it were an open bidding process. Every team has to react as if they were a small company trying to make the best bid and win the competition.

At 10AM UTC, every team should start self-organizing and quickly solve the following questions:

1. Define an internal distribution of responsibilities (it is expected that every team appoints at least one spokesperson, one person responsible for web server access and another person that will be responsible for audiovisual tasks and equipment; apart from that, your internal structure should be just as hierarchical as you find it necessary)
2. Find a name for the team
3. Define an internal organisation in subgroups or "task forces" of members with specific skills
4. Define the work packages, tasks and subtasks, and assign them to the relevant sub teams and team members.

The answer to those questions will be collected before the end of the first day.

The team then starts to work in a classical project management process: design a book of specifications and technical choices, then implement it. This document should be delivered to the teaching team on Day 4 (Thursday, March 26th at the end of the day: 6 pm French time).

This book of specifications and technical choices must include a data model that fits the requirements of the system on a conceptual level and on an organizational model. It must also describe the choices regarding the system's UX/UI.

On Day 5 (Friday, March 27th, at the end of the day), each team is expected to deliver their graphic charter and communication strategy document.

Halfway through the cycle (on Tuesday, March 31st), each team is expected to give a short progress report to the teaching team, and say where they stand in the process. Individual assessment is carried out at this point of project: each member is expected to present their part of the work done by providing evidence (e.g. extracts of deliverables).

On that same day (Tuesday, March 31st), each team is expected to deliver a beta version of the public section of the website even if not completely functional yet.

At the end of the cycle (on Friday, April 3rd), each team will have to present the results of their work in front of the jury.

There are no particular constraints on the language(s) you to use for internal communication, the digital media you use for communicating, or the digital platforms you use for exchanging files and project data. There are plenty of choices available, and it is up to you to find which one best suits your needs.

However, English might be convenient as most of the participants may speak it fluently. And a Discord server is available for you to start with and deliver the different documents:

https://discord.gg/rmuVzbtE

3. Assessment

The assessment will be based on what you present on the last day (April 3rd) in front of the jury.

The language of the presentation on the last day should be English.

Your teamwork will be marked from 0 to 20. A mark below 10 means you failed. All other marks allow you to get the ECTS credits (above 10 = pass, above 12 = fair, above 14 = good, above 16 = excellent).

The mark is given based on an assessment of your work on different criteria, both individually and as part of team (how far have the project goals been met, quality of the graphic design, quality of the presentation…)

An important evaluation criterion is how well people in the team have worked together. During the presentation, it should be made clear to the jury who has done what in the project. Some explanations should also be given about how the problem of collaborating online across different countries has been solved.

If available, the online partners may take part in the presentation either through a live video call or by providing a pre-recorded video in which they present the work they have done.

The final mark is individual. It is mainly composed of team assessments and weighted with individual assessments.

Every team will have up to 30 minutes to present themselves and present their work. The presentation will then be followed by 10 minutes of questions from the jury.

A classic presentation plan includes:

- a presentation of the team
- an explanation on how the workload was distributed
- a description of the choices made in graphic design
- an explanation of the implementation choices
- a description of the communication strategy to make the website known (online and offline)
- a demonstration of the prototype
- a presentation of the video clip
- a conclusion about the learnings from that experience.

On the day of the final presentation, every team should give sample printed communication matter (e.g. flyers) to the jury.

4. Project Requirements

4.1. Context and problematics

The collaborative web has created opportunities for people across the globe to share their knowledge and experience even when they don't meet in person. This trend has accelerated since the year 2020, when many people were compelled to stay at home because of the covid-19 pandemics. And 6 years later, it has become the norm for users around the world.

However, the different generations rarely mix, as platforms are designed to suit each of them. We notice that age groups with specific interests are more likely to create communities than transgenerational exchanges. Yet elderly and younger generations have a lot to learn from each other– skills, experience, life history– and a widening gap between generations is not a good thing for society as a whole.

Information and Communication Technology may offer tools to alleviate this lack of communication. This is why we ask you to design a cross-generational meeting communication and learning platform that will allow people from different countries and generations to get in contact online, and exchange skills and experience.

4.2. Goals

The aim of this project is to build a multilingual web portal allowing people from different countries and generations:

– to subscribe and declare the type of experience they are willing to share with others

– to find other people with whom they would have a mutual interest in exchanging online

– to make appointments and hold online meetings (possibly using 3rd-party platforms).

On the day of the presentation, the project should include a prototype demonstrating the feasibility of such a web-based portal, as well as an example of use, with a (possibly pre-recorded) video exchange.

A communication strategy should also be planned to allow for the portal to become known by the target audience.

4.3. Site features

The website should offer a public section and a private section.

It must be fully available in three languages.

You will find below a list of features that could be expected from the website.

4.3.1. Public section

The public section of the website (accessible from any internet user) should contain:

– a home page, containing a presentation of the platform, and a summary of its functionalities (with links)

– a short video clip (3 min. max) advertising possible uses of the platform, featuring users reporting their experience (in addition to live action shootings, videos may include some motion design and/or video screen recordings)

– visible from everywhere on the site, at the bottom of the scrollable page, a list of site information links, pointing to pages such as “About us”, “Questions”..

Important, also at the bottom of the scrollable page, and compulsory:

– a link “Legal information” (French: « Mentions légales »), pointing to a page where the compulsory legal information is given,

– and a link “User agreement and terms of service”(French: « Conditions Générales d’Utilisation »), pointing to a page giving the users information about the terms they agree to when using the site.

Before subscribing to the platform, the users should somehow tick a box whereby they accept the terms of service. In the terms of service, they should be reminded that the discussions and contents they share must comply to their country’s regulations, and also to a certain number of good practice rules that it is up to you to specify (traditionally, rules of this type include not calling for hate or murder, not expressing racist or sexist views, etc.).

And according to the General Data Protection Regulation, a link “Privacy policy” (French: « Politique de confidentialité »), pointing to a page where the compulsory legal information about data is given; those texts should conform the national and international regulations concerning databases.

– visible from everywhere on the site, at a fixed position on the viewport (classically in the top right corner), an invitation to sign up (subscribe) or to sign in (connect);

– clicking on “sign up”/“subscribe” should get the user to an account creation screen;

– clicking on “sign in”/“connect” should get the user to an authentication screen where users who already have an account may give their credentials and get access to the private section.

The video clip(s) may be hosted on our server, or on a 3rd-party video hosting platform (the use of independent, decentralized solutions like PeerTube is encouraged, but the use of well-known proprietary hosting platforms like Vimeo, Dailymotion, or YouTube is not forbidden).

It should be subtitled in all of the languages of your site. Depending on the current language choice, the video should automatically play with the corresponding subtitles (the language of the subtitles can be sent among the parameters of the GET request to the public video hosting platform that hosts the embedded video).

The ideal video to be included in the public section of the site should display the cross-cultural and cross-generational aspects of the platform, by showing a sample dialogue between two "personas" of different countries and ages sharing stories, skills or experience; and later witnessing to the viewers how they appreciate this kind of exchange.

It is very important to obtain a written consent from the people featured in the sample video for their image to be used on a publicly accessible web site (it is, of course, not necessary to disclose their real identity, as they ought to represent personas more than actual people).

The pages of the public section of the website should be available in at least three languages. The teams should take advantage of their internal linguistic skills.

4.3.2. Private section (accessible with credentials)

It should not be forgotten that this network is private and should comply with the General Data Protection Regulation. This is an important requirement of the network.

The platform should provide a way for users to find other users on the base of mutual interests, then to get in contact with them and organize online meetings — but only among people who have subscribed to the platform and agreed to the legal conditions.

The private section should contain:

1° A way, for registered users, to mention (a) the languages they speak, (b) their geographical location, and (c) the experiences they may share and think might interest other people.

These experiences may include a broad understanding of the meaning of the word "experience", from specific skills (mending a shirt, preparing a recipe, photoshopping a digital picture...) to conversational exchanges with a purpose of language learning, or even telling pieces of life history, or personal accounts of past or present events.

It is better if there are two ways to describe skills: one by predefined categories or hashtags (that the website team would have translated in the different languages in advance), and one by free text in the users' target language.

2° A way to access a database of other users; this should not be a plain list, but a searchable interface including a map of geographical locations, and also the possibility to apply filters by language and skill-describing hashtags or search terms.

3° An internal messaging system allowing the users to exchange messages via the platform without a need to disclose their e-mail addresses in the first place. The delivery of messages is submitted to social networking constraints (see below, § 4).

4° A simple and visible way to access the public sections of the site without disconnecting.

5° Visible at a fixed position on the viewport (same as in the public section, see 4.3.1), an invitation to sign out (disconnect).

Once logged in the private section of the platform, the users may access all of the functions described above. The online meetings may take place either as written discussions using the internal message board (4.3.2, §3), or as online video meetings involving a 3rd-party operator.

4.4. Implementation

A LAMP server will be available for you to upload your site. At the end of the project the site will be visible under the hierarchy of the host http://international.iut-bobigny.univ-paris13.fr. In every team, the person responsible for server access is individually in charge of the team's credentials on the server, and this should be an individual responsibility.

The development language shall be PHP and the relational database system MariaDB.

4.5. *Communication and graphic design*

Should your team want to launch your platform in the real world, you would need to make it well-known and easily recognizable. You are asked to plan a communication strategy to make your new service known to the targeted audience, and to design a recognizable visual identity.

4.5.1. Communication strategy

Digital network communication:

– The video mentioned in 4.3.1 should be hosted either on our server, or on a public video hosting network (like PeerTube), or platform (like Vimeo, YouTube or DailyMotion).

A digital communication campaign on other networks (Facebook, X, Instagram...) is requested and should be exposed and explained.

4.5.2 Creative strategy

The graphic designers will be in charge of all visual files for the website; they will also see to printed matter (posters, flyers).

Then they will have to set up the graphic specifications, finalize the graphic side of the project and defend it.

It is required that the site designers take particular care in imagining intuitive interfaces to ensure a smooth user experience with a navigation menu that always remains visible, a way to follow the navigation path, the use of colour codes, etc.

Their work will be summed up in a document called graphic charter. The graphic charter describes:

– the visual aspect of the site

– the logotype and its possible variants

– the brand identity that has been defined to communicate on different media; (including interface and banners on auxiliary networks: Vimeo or YouTube channel, social networks if applicable...)

– graphic elements included in the video tutorial (e.g. motion design, panels, decoration)

– posters and flyers designed to promote the network when launched

4.6 Additional features

1° A way for every user to declare a “social” relationship with another user (the platform technically is a social network, and as any network it should have nodes and edges).

The social relationship needs not be symmetrical (like “friend” on Facebook) but may be asymmetrical (like “follower” on Instagram): this design choice is up to you. It is also up to you to decide how this social relationship should be called (be creative!)

When user A declares to be connected to user B (A → B), then B may see A’s agenda and A may read B’s messages and public events.

When a user A sends a message to a user B and B has not yet “accepted” A in their relational network (B ↛ A), then only the first message of A is transmitted to B, with an invitation to “accept” A, i.e. to connect to A on their side too (B A). This is all somehow simpler if the relation is symmetrical.

2° A view on a personal agenda, allowing users to plan their online meetings.

Every user should be able to add (a) private events, (b) shared events, and (c) public events, to their personal agenda.

(a) Private events are meant to be used as reminders to oneself (e.g. appointment to the doctor), and the details provided— if any—are only visible to the user themself: to other users, it should appear as a grey (or red) block, with the only function of preventing the setting of shared events including the affected user.

(b) Shared events are meant to programme two-way (or n-way) online meetings between connected users. They imply validation by all the concerned users (a fortiori, this implies that the users have all accepted to connect to the organizing user and the other way around).

Once validated by all sides, they become visible on the personal agendas of all the concerned users. The events themselves (text chat or online meeting), when they occur, should only be accessible to the appointed users.

(c) Public events are meant as broadcasts from one user to all registered users of the platform. For example, when some user A wants to share their recipe for a banana cake with everybody, they declare it as a public event. Any user B may see it and attend it provided they have “connected” to A (B A).

Partners: IUT de Bobigny, Université Sorbonne Paris-Nord,USPN (France); University of Tirana,UT (Albania); Hanoi University of Science, VNU (Vietnam).

Questions on the project may be directed to: Chan Leduc (web development)/ Laure Frèches (communication strategy)/ Alice Herniaux (audiovisual and graphic design)/ Elodie Tardieu (internal communication and project management)